

MODULE 42 · EXAM STRATEGY - ALL DOMAINS

What Changed

Where your study material is confidently wrong, and how to tell.

DOMAIN Cross-cutting EXAM WEIGHT All four MODULE 42 of 44

First, a date you need

- ◆ **The last day to take SAP-C02 is 16 November 2026.** Registration for SAP-C03 opens on 27 October.
- ◆ **SAP-C03 moves from four domains to five**, adding generative and agentic AI, post-quantum cryptography and resilience engineering.
- ◆ If you are prepared, sit C02 before the deadline. Your certification stays valid for its full term either way.
- ◆ This course targets C02. Most of it transfers, and the new C03 material is genuinely new.

ON THE EXAM

Recorded on 2 September 2026. Check the AWS certification page before booking, because dates and details do move.

The exam lags the console, and study material lags the exam. **This module maps that gap.**

Renamed, and still examinable

NOW CALLED	YOU WILL SEE IT AS
AWS Security Hub CSPM	AWS Security Hub. The exam list uses the old name
Amazon Quick / Quick Suite	Amazon QuickSight
Aurora Serverless	Aurora Serverless v2, renamed April 2026
Amazon Data Firehose	Kinesis Data Firehose
AWS Transform MGN	AWS Application Migration Service
CloudWatch Database Insights	RDS Performance Insights

ON THE EXAM

Answer with the behaviour, not the branding. A rename never changes what a service does, and the exam tests what it does.

Closed to new customers, still examinable

SERVICE	STATUS
AWS Migration Hub	Closed 7 Nov 2025. Still on the in-scope list
Application Discovery Service	Closed 7 Nov 2025. Still in scope
Snowball Edge	Closed 7 Nov 2025. Support ends 31 Dec 2026
AWS App Runner	Closed 30 Apr 2026. Successor is ECS Express Mode
Simple AD	Closed 30 Jul 2026
Systems Manager Change Manager	Closed to new customers

ON THE EXAM

All still correct exam answers. Recognise the shape a scenario describes and answer with the service, even though you could not buy it today.

Answers that changed

THE OLD ANSWER	THE CURRENT ONE
Above 16,000 IOPS needs io2	gp3 reaches 80,000 IOPS and 64 TiB
Retain, delete, re-import to split a stack	CloudFormation stack refactoring, in one operation
Provisioned capacity is cheaper for steady DynamoDB	On-demand is now AWS's recommended default
Savings Plans cover compute only	Database Savings Plans arrived Dec 2025
Only unattached Elastic IPs are charged	All public IPv4 charged hourly since Feb 2024
Snowmobile for petabyte transfers	Retired. Cluster Snowball Edge devices

ON THE EXAM

Each of these was correct for years. That is what makes them dangerous: they are remembered confidently and rarely re-checked.

Newer capabilities worth recognising

- ◆ **GuardDuty Extended Threat Detection** correlates many findings into one critical attack sequence, automatically and at no extra cost.
- ◆ **Centralized root access management** deletes root credentials across member accounts. New accounts have none by default.
- ◆ **Just-in-time node access** removes standing permission to connect, with Cedar approval policies.
- ◆ **CloudFront VPC origins** reach a private ALB directly, replacing the secret custom header pattern.

ON THE EXAM

These four are the most likely to appear as the correct answer while being absent from older material entirely.

How to tell when your knowledge is stale

- ◆ **Specific numeric limits** age fastest. IOPS ceilings, retention periods, throughput caps and instance sizes all move.
- ◆ **Pricing-derived rules** age next. "Provisioned is cheaper" was a conclusion, not a fact, and the price changed.
- ◆ **Behavioural facts age slowest.** A queue message is still consumed and gone. An SCP still follows the identity.
- ◆ So anchor on behaviour, and treat any remembered number as something to sanity-check.

ON THE EXAM

If your answer depends on a specific number or on which option is cheaper, that is exactly where to be least confident.

A design review proposes io2 Block Express for a database needing 30,000 IOPS on a 6 TiB volume, with single-digit millisecond latency and no clustering. The reviewer's stated justification is that gp3 cannot exceed 16,000 IOPS.

Cost is a stated concern.

What should the solutions architect say?

- ☐ A gp3 now reaches 80,000 IOPS and 64 TiB, so it meets every stated requirement at lower cost
- ☐ B Approve io2 Block Express as proposed
- ☐ C Stripe three gp3 volumes in RAID 0
- ☐ D Use io1, which is cheaper than io2

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the solutions architect say?

- A** gp3 meets it, cheaper
30,000 IOPS and 6 TiB are both inside gp3's current limits, and the scenario rules out every remaining reason for io2.
- B** Approve io2
Would work, at higher cost, on a justification that stopped being true in September 2025.
- C** RAID 0 striping
The workaround from when one volume could not deliver enough. Unnecessary complexity and a wider failure surface.
- D** io1
An older generation of the same idea. It also does not question the premise, which is where the error is.

THE SIGNAL

Notice what the scenario rules out: no sub-millisecond need, no Multi-Attach, no five-nines requirement. Every io2 reason is closed off.

A team must split a monolithic CloudFormation stack into three, with no downtime and no resource replacement. A senior engineer describes the procedure: set DeletionPolicy to Retain, remove resources from the template, delete the stack, then import into new stacks. They have done this successfully before.

What should the solutions architect advise?

- ☐ A Use CloudFormation stack refactoring, which does this in one operation without replacement
- ☐ B Follow the retain-and-reimport procedure as described
- ☐ C Recreate the resources in three new stacks and migrate data
- ☐ D Convert to nested stacks under a parent template

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the solutions architect advise?

- A

 Stack refactoring
Purpose-built since February 2025 to move resources between stacks and rename logical IDs, in one operation, with no replacement.
- B

 Retain and re-import
The engineer is right that it works, and it is many manual steps with a window where nothing manages the resources.
- C

 Recreate and migrate
Replaces every resource and requires data migration, contradicting both stated constraints.
- D

 Nested stacks
Keeps one lifecycle, so the coupling that motivated the split remains.

THE SIGNAL

The engineer's experience is real and dated. "I have done this before" is evidence about the past, not about what is available now.

A DynamoDB table has run at a steady 5,000 read units and 2,000 write units for two years, on provisioned capacity with auto scaling. A cost review recommends keeping provisioned capacity, citing the standard guidance that provisioned is cheaper for predictable workloads.

The table was configured in 2023.

What should the solutions architect advise?

- ☐ A Model it against on-demand, which AWS has recommended as the default since the November 2024 price cut
- ☐ B Keep provisioned capacity as recommended
- ☐ C Buy DynamoDB reserved capacity to deepen the discount
- ☐ D Move the table to Aurora, which is cheaper at steady load

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the solutions architect advise?

- A

Model against on-demand
AWS halved on-demand pricing in Nov 2024 and now calls it the default for most workloads. Note the wording: model it, rather than switch blindly.
- B

Keep provisioned
Correct guidance for years, and it is a conclusion drawn from a price that has since changed by half.
- C

Reserved capacity
Deepens a commitment to a mode that may no longer be cheaper. Measure before committing for a year.
- D

Move to Aurora
Replaces the database to change a billing mode, and Aurora would not serve this access pattern better.

THE SIGNAL

This is a pricing-derived rule, the second-fastest category to age. The rule was a conclusion; the price underneath it moved.

A scenario describes a company needing a fully managed way to run a container image as a scaling HTTPS service, with no load balancer, target groups or scaling policies to configure. Four options are offered, one of which is AWS App Runner.

The candidate knows App Runner closed to new customers in April 2026.

What should the candidate do?

- ☐ A Choose App Runner: it matches the described shape and remains on the exam's in-scope service list
- ☐ B Eliminate App Runner, since it cannot be adopted today
- ☐ C Choose ECS Express Mode instead, as the successor
- ☐ D Choose EKS, since it is the most current option

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the candidate do?

- A

 Choose App Runner
The exam tests the in-scope list, and App Runner is on it. Knowing more than the exam does is only useful if you answer the exam's question.
- B

 Eliminate it
Over-applying real-world knowledge. Commercial availability is not what the exam is assessing.
- C

 ECS Express Mode
The right real-world answer and probably not among the options. If it were, App Runner would still be the exam's answer.
- D

 EKS
Contradicts the requirement. The scenario asks for nothing to configure, and EKS is the opposite.

THE SIGNAL

Currency knowledge is for the workplace and for confidence. On the exam, answer the in-scope list, and let the shape decide.

A security review needs to confirm that the organisation's GuardDuty deployment, enabled in 2022, is still detecting everything it can. The console shows GuardDuty as enabled and healthy in all 90 accounts, with no findings suppressed.

The reviewer concludes coverage is complete.

What should the solutions architect check?

- A Which protection plans are enabled: plans launched after GuardDuty was first enabled are not turned on automatically
- B Nothing; enabled and healthy in every account is complete coverage
- C Whether the delegated administrator is correctly registered
- D Whether findings are being exported to S3

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

What should the solutions architect check?

- A

 Which protection plans are on
Documented behaviour: a plan released after you enabled GuardDuty stays off, and the console still reports healthy. A 2022 deployment lags by years.
- B

 Coverage is complete
Enabled and healthy means it is running, not that it is watching everything it could. That is exactly the reviewer's error.
- C

 Delegated administrator
Worth confirming, and it affects who sees findings rather than which findings are generated.
- D

 Export to S3
Affects retention and downstream processing. It does not change detection coverage.

THE SIGNAL

This is a currency question wearing an operations costume. The service did not change; what it can see did, and nothing surfaced that.

A candidate is revising from a well-regarded study guide published in 2023. It states that Savings Plans cover only EC2, Lambda and Fargate, that Snowmobile handles petabyte-scale transfers, and that unattached Elastic IPs are the only ones charged.

All three statements were accurate when written.

How should the candidate treat this material?

- ☐ A Trust the behavioural explanations, and re-check every specific limit, price and service status against current AWS documentation
- ☐ B Discard the guide entirely, since it contains errors
- ☐ C Trust it fully, since it was accurate when published
- ☐ D Trust the numbers and re-check only the service names

◆ PAUSE AND DECIDE

How should the candidate treat this material?

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|--|--|
| <p>A Trust behaviour, re-check numbers</p> <p>Behavioural explanations age slowest and are the guide's real value. Limits, prices and service status age fastest and are cheap to verify.</p> | <p>B Discard it</p> <p><i>Overcorrects. A good 2023 guide still explains why a queue differs from a stream, and that has not changed.</i></p> |
| <p>C Trust it fully</p> <p><i>All three quoted statements are now wrong. Accurate when written is not the same as accurate.</i></p> | <p>D Numbers yes, names no</p> <p><i>Exactly inverted. Numbers are the fastest-ageing category, and renames rarely change the correct answer.</i></p> |

THE SIGNAL

Option D is the interesting wrong answer because it sounds like a sensible policy. It just gets the ageing order backwards.

What to carry out of this module

- ◆ **Sit SAP-C02 by 16 November 2026** if you are prepared. C03 registration opens on 27 October.
- ◆ **Answer the in-scope list**, even for services closed to new customers. Knowing more than the exam can cost marks.
- ◆ **Numbers age fastest, then pricing rules, then behaviour.** Be least confident about a remembered limit.
- ◆ **Renames never change behaviour.** Answer with what the service does, whatever it is currently called.

ON THE EXAM

"I have done this before" and "the guide says" are both evidence about the past. On a platform this fast, that is a different claim.